

Source Amnesia Trace Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	source-amnesia-trace

Big idea: Remembering a claim is not the same as remembering why it deserved trust.

Overview

Students hear claims from different sources, then later test whether they remember the claim, the source, or both.

Student Prompt

Inspect Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Claim: 'Spacing revision improves long-term memory' paired first with 'cognitive scientist', then later shown without source. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Claim: 'Blue light glasses double focus' paired first with 'online advert', then later shown without source. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Source Amnesia Trace Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Claim: 'Blue light glasses double focus' paired first with 'online advert', then later shown without source. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Remembering a claim is not the same as remembering why it deserved trust.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	What happens to justification when we forget the source of a belief?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how remembering a claim is not the same as remembering why it deserved trust.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Pair each claim with a visibly different source label, then remove the labels for the recall phase.
- Use a short distractor task between exposure and recall so source memory has time to fade.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Claim: 'Spacing revision improves long-term memory' paired first with 'cognitive scientist', then later shown without source.
- Claim: 'Blue light glasses double focus' paired first with 'online advert', then later shown without source.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Show students a short set of claims, each paired with a different source type.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	After a distractor task, give students the claims again without sources.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students mark whether they remember the claim and then identify its original source.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Reveal the source pairings and compare content memory with source memory.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how source memory affects justification and responsible belief.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- A claim can feel familiar even when its original justification has disappeared.
- What should happen to trust when source memory is weak?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat perception or memory as a recording device.
- Students may assume confidence is evidence rather than a feeling about evidence.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Separates perception, memory, belief, confidence, and justification.
- Uses the activity result to make a cautious claim about knowers.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use six claims and three source types.
- Challenge: include two claims that are true but from weak sources and false but from confident sources.

Extension Tasks

- Students audit one belief they hold and trace where it probably came from.
- Connect source amnesia to citation, rumours, and social media reposting.

Related Activities

- False Memory Word List
- Confidence Calibration Test
- Eyewitness Trap